

Student / Futures

Creative Careers in Animation, Computer Graphics, and Interactive Techniques

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ABSTRACT

Industry panelists share perspectives and insights for students, educators, and creative professionals who are considering careers in animation, computer graphics, creative technologies, and interactive techniques. Within rapid and ever-expanding fields of technological change, many creative industries are reaching critical inflection points. Changing workplace cultures, advances in machine learning and artificial intelligence, real-time graphics and virtual production systems, edge computing and ever-faster network communications are all radically transforming the forms and capacities of creative industries and cultural production. A variety of opportunities and unforeseen challenges are exposed along the way. In this panel, creative industry representatives discuss the general and specific states of their fields, providing insights into changing career paradigms. Discussion includes advice for educators to help prepare students to meet the challenges and opportunities that currently face creative industries, as well as the preparation and training needed to anticipate change. Panelists consider what qualities make for desirable applicants in their respective fields, with insights for individuals who are preparing to enter creative industries, as well as for those considering career transitions. Represented industry segments include animation and VFX, computer graphics and information systems, themed entertainment, and interactive educational technologies. Questions considered include how pedagogy can help prepare and empower students for successful creative careers; what entry-level applicants should have (and should not have) on resumes, portfolios, and demo reels; and what can creative talents do to proactively acquire requisite credentials. Discussion will expose fresh outlooks on the futures of creative fields in animation, computer graphics, and interactive techniques.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Applied computing** → Arts and humanities; Education; • **Social and professional topics** → Professional topics.

KEYWORDS

Education, Creative Careers, Entry-level Employment, Demo Reels

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1 PANELISTS

Johannes DeYoung (moderator) is an artist and educator who works at the intersection of computational and material processes. He is appointed Associate Professor of Electronic and Time-Based Media at Carnegie Mellon University School of Art in Pittsburgh, PA. His work has been exhibited internationally in major galleries and museums in countries such as Spain, Taiwan, Germany, USA, Canada, Ireland, and Australia, as well as being featured in The New York Times, The New York Post, The Huffington Post, and Dossier Journal. He has lectured on his work at institutions and venues such as Yale University School of Art; Pennsylvania Academy of Fine Arts; Tyler School of Art at Temple University; Landmark Arts Gallery at Texas Tech University School of Art; Lyme Academy College of Fine Arts; the Society for Animation Studies; MODE Summit; the IEEE Games, Entertainment, and Media conference; CINANIMA International Animated Film Festival; and the University Film and Video Association. From 2008–2018, he was appointed Senior Critic at Yale University School of Art and founding Director of the Center for Collaborative Arts and Media. He received his MFA from the Cranbrook Academy of Art in Bloomfield Hills, MI.

Claudia Davis is the Sr. Technology Development and Engagement Manager at LAIKA Studios. Her department bridges the unique gap between studio artists and software developers, enabling better communication and collaboration between LAIKA's physical fabrication and stage groups, and the creative developers who build tools for artistic production. Previously, Claudia worked for Yale University as a Systems Analyst & Web Producer. Exemplified through her volunteer work with the Massive Collaborative Animation Projects, a project born out of the ACM SIGGRAPH Education Committee, her work explores the methods by which leadership can be more mindful of their own emotional intelligence to promote a better working environment and achieve better outcomes in creative production environments. Davis' public speaking engagements center such topics as "Emphasizing Empathy in the

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Pipeline Process” (SIGGRAPH 2018) and ”Making Time for Emotional Intelligence in Production and Technology” (SIGGRAPH 2020) through discussion of the management philosophy around common production work stressors and how these factors have been exacerbated by both remote work and COVID-19.

Clint Fanelli is a Sr. Art Manager at Duolingo. He oversees talent development, staffing, and headcount planning across animation productions as well as contributes to Creative Strategy for Duolingo’s Design Studio. He is an experienced producer and animation team builder with professional experiences spanning roles across various industries, including work as an Associate Producer on the television series “Ask the StoryBots” (2015–16); Producer and Sr. Operations Manager at Hallmark Labs (2016–18); and the Artist Manager for the Character TD and Crowds departments at Walt Disney Animation Studios (2018–21). Prior to this pursuit in animation production, Fanelli served as a Middle School Language Arts teacher for Volusia County Florida (2011–12). Fanelli is passionate about life-long learning, which he brings to his work managing animation teams, building studios, and growing talent.

Mike Stroud is the Lead Recruiter for LAIKA Studios. Mike supports business operation recruiting at LAIKA, ranging from Systems Technology, IT, Marketing, Finance, Administrative Services and Human Resources, as well as oversight of the summer internship program. He has over 14 years of experience in Talent Acquisition, including an array of different industries. He has worked in non-profit mental health, healthcare, regulated energy, Food Manufacturing CPG and now the film industry. Mike believes in fostering relationship building through honesty and transparency. He takes a supportive approach to share what he has learned in the last 14 years to mentor students who are starting their career path.

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